AEP FROM ZERO • PART 2 • SPEAK TO YOUR CUSTOMER (AJO)

EPISODE 20

AJO Personalization Tutorial: Fallback, If-Else

Learn Adobe Journey Optimizer (AJO) personalization from zero: add a first-name fallback so an empty field never prints “Hi ,”, and write an if-else condition on a loyalty field with the right PQL syntax and case-sensitive field paths. You will see why a wrong tenant prefix makes a personalised email show a blank, use AJO conditional content, and read the code it generates to debug a variant that never shows. You will simulate content on two test profiles, decide between a content variant and a journey

Previously: one voice, one broken greeting

- Last time: one channel configuration, one priority
- Footer fragment's opt-out cleared the warning
- Still broken: an empty name prints “Hi ,”
- Also unguarded: a Silver member told she is Gold
- Today: fallbacks, if-else, conditional content
- Goal: copy that agrees with its audience

KEY IDEA

Bloom's emails share one voice now, but the welcome still greets an empty name with Hi and a bare comma. Today: personalisation that never embarrasses.

The most preventable failure in email

The greeting asks for a first name

▼

Rohan's seat: first name empty

▼

Nothing to print, no default given

▼

The email reads “Hi ,”

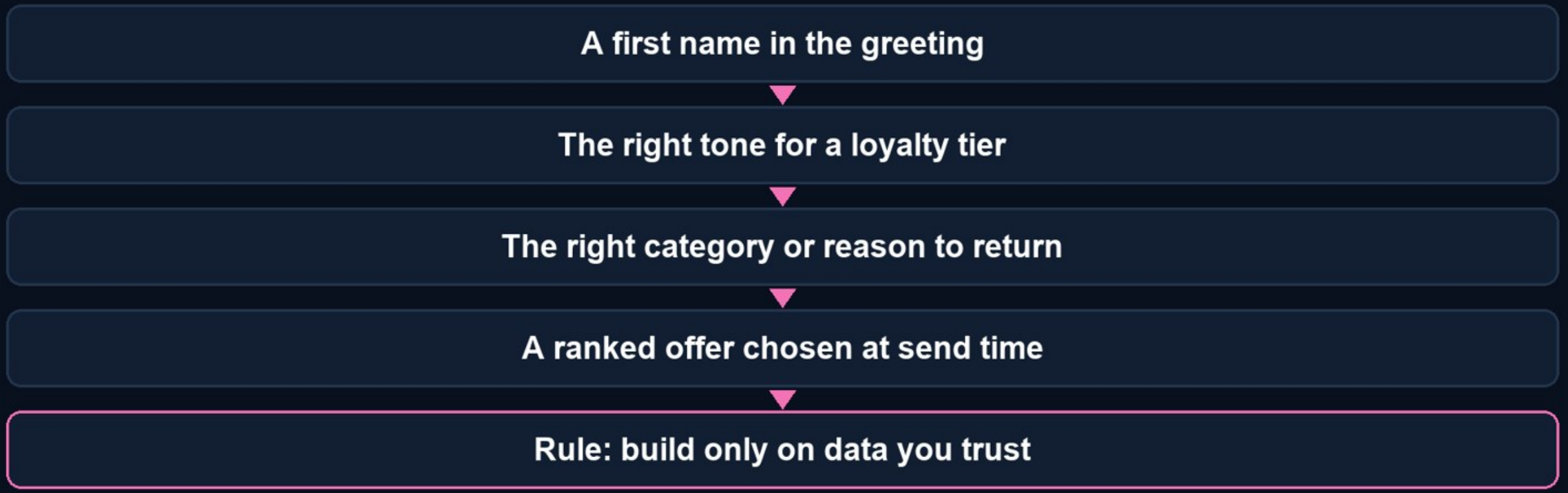
▼

A customer sees a careless brand

KEY IDEA

An empty field printed “Hi ,”. Divya calls it the most preventable failure in email, and it must be fixed before relaunch Monday.

Personalisation is a spectrum



KEY IDEA

From a first name to a ranked offer chosen at send time. Build only on data you trust: a field that is forty percent empty makes awkward emails.

Value tokens: how a name gets into an email

Piece	What it looks like
Value token	{{profile.person.name.firstName}}
Value with a fallback	{%= …firstName ?: "there" %}
Condition	{%#if … = "Gold"%} … {%/if%}

Syntax as documented for Adobe Journey Optimizer, 2026

KEY IDEA

A token asks the profile for a value at send time. Handlebars-style tokens print values; Profile Query Language, PQL, adds fallbacks and conditions.

First-name fallback: write it first

- Plain token, empty name: “Hi ,”
- Fallback: {%= …firstName ?: "there" %}
- Result: “Hi Priya,” or “Hi there,”
- Editor: ellipsis, then Insert with fallback text
- Habit: write the fallback first

KEY IDEA

Give every token a default that reads naturally. Insert with fallback text adds it for you: Hi Priya, or Hi there, never a bare comma.

If-else: one line, two kinds of customer

- If tier = "Gold": the early-access perk
- Else: “Reach Gold to unlock early access”
- Path: profile._bloom.loyalty.tier
- One equals sign, not two
- Practise in your own draft, named with initials

KEY IDEA

An if-else line shows Gold members a perk and everyone else a nudge. It needs a single equals sign and the exact path under underscore bloom.

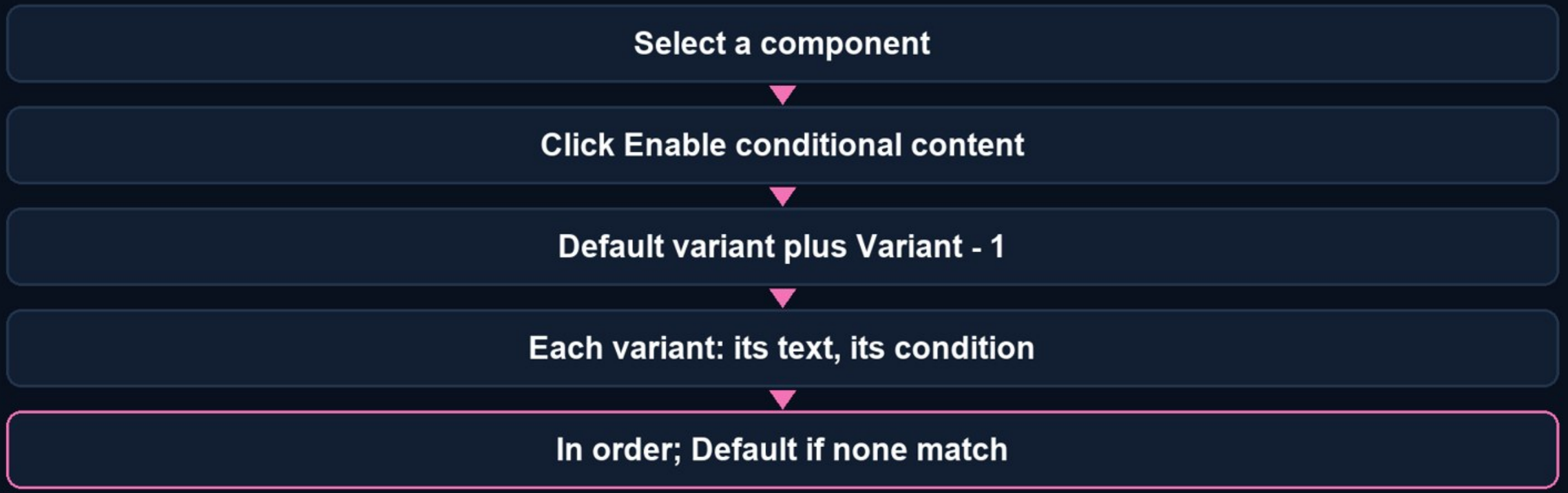
Why a personalised token renders blank

Cause	Fix
Field empty, no fallback	Add a fallback that reads well
Wrong case: firstname, not firstName	Copy the path from a real profile
Wrong or missing tenant prefix	Custom fields sit under _bloom

KEY IDEA

Three causes: the field is empty with no fallback, the path has the wrong case, or the tenant prefix is wrong. The prefix is the most common.

Conditional content: the no-code way



KEY IDEA

Conditional content swaps a block per customer without code: a Default variant plus ordered variants, each with its own condition.

Read the generated code: if false

Default variant: the Gold perk

▼

Variant - 1: the nudge, no condition

▼

Generated code: {%#if false %}

▼

Variant - 1 can never show

▼

Everyone sees the Gold perk

▼

Safer: perk in the conditioned variant

KEY IDEA

Kavya's variant had no saved condition, so the designer wrote “if false”. It could never show, and everyone got the Gold perk from the Default variant.

Two seats, and the line that lied

- Simulate content (AEP profiles): real test seats
- TD-KAVYA-01, Gold: the perk line
- TD-FARHAN-02, Silver: “Reach Gold to unlock…”
- Static line still says “one of our Gold members”
- Subject: name token with no fallback
- Fix: Gold claims inside the if; subject fallback

KEY IDEA

Kavya's Gold seat saw the perk and Farhan's Silver seat saw the nudge, but a static Gold line still showed to him. Copy and audience must agree.

Variant or journey branch?

Situation	Choose
Gold perk line in a thank-you	Content variant: same intent
Greeting with or without a name	A fallback, not even a variant
Thank a loyalist or win back a lapser	Branch or journey: different intent
A different wait or channel next	Journey branch

KEY IDEA

Same message, different detail: use a content variant. Different intent: use a journey branch. One email beats five near-identical copies.

When not to personalise

- Weak inference: generic is safer
- Customers forgive generic, remember wrong
- One product view is not a skin profile
- Senior answer: not responsibly, not yet
- Every dynamic block still needs a fallback

KEY IDEA

If the inference is weak, generic is safer. Customers forgive a generic email, but they remember a confidently wrong one.

Interview corner

- “Write the fallback first.”
- It forces the message to work without data
- Add: copy must agree with the audience
- Prove each variant on a test seat of each kind

KEY IDEA

“Write the fallback first.” It shows you design for missing data, which is exactly where personalisation fails in production.

Recap, your question, and the waiting cart

- Write the fallback first, subject line too
- One equals sign; exact, case-sensitive paths
- Read the generated code: “if false” never shows
- Copy and audience must agree
- Next: Cart Rescue v1

KEY IDEA

Fallbacks first, exact paths, read the generated code, and copy that agrees with its audience.
Next: Cart Rescue, the journey that pays for it all.